

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being kind and full of ideas.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, or let an older child read. Pause at the questions and let everyone share their ideas. There are no wrong answers, only new ones to try.

Before you begin

Market day on the home island is the busiest, brightest morning of the week. All along the Market Row the stalls are heaped high: warm loaves cooling on the baker's counter, ripe fruit stacked in glowing pyramids, neat rows of shoes at the cobbler's, and a whole rainbow of toys waiting to be wound up and played with.

Then comes a small flash, a soft pop, and a sound like the whole market drawing a surprised breath. When it clears, everything has jumped to the wrong place. The baker stands blinking at a pair of muddy boots. The cobbler turns a kite over in puzzled hands. Fruit sits where toys should be, toys where bread should be, and not a single stallholder can find a thing that belongs to them.

You are young mages, and a tangle like this is exactly the sort of thing you are learning to mend. You share a quick look and roll up your sleeves. "Let us untangle the market," you say, and the muddle waits for you.



What is your mage name? Which magic feels most like you today: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?

Stop 1 The Muddled Stalls

You make your way down the row, and everywhere you look an object sits where it does not belong, looking faintly bewildered. A pair of boots blinks up at you from among the loaves, as if to ask how on earth it ended up there.

The Mist Cat pads out of the morning haze and settles at your side, soft and grey and ready to lend a paw.



How will you discover where each thing belongs? Could you simply ask the objects themselves where their home is? Try something, and see what the market tells you.

Once the objects begin to name their proper stalls, you set to work carrying them home, and the easy ones are soon back in their places. But a handful are still hopelessly jumbled, and for those you will need to think a little harder.

Stop 2 The Memory of the Market

To untangle the rest, you must call up a picture of the market as it was before the spell went wrong: which stall held which goods, and exactly where everything stood. That is no small thing, with the whole row shuffled around you.

A Talking Flower, nodding in its pot on the corner, leans close and hums the market back to you in order, stall by stall, like a little song you can lean on.



Can you remember which stall sold the bread, which the fruit, which the shoes, and which the toys? Match each muddled thing back to the stall it came from.

As each thing returns to where it began, more and more of the Market Row settles into happy order again. Only one stubborn knot is left, and it is the trickiest of them all.

Stop 3 The Last Swap

Three stalls remain tangled, and they are tangled in a ring. The baker is holding a pair of boots, the cobbler is holding a kite, and the toymaker is holding a fresh loaf of bread. Every one of them has something that belongs to one of the others, and to set it right you must work out, carefully, who should pass which thing along to whom.



Who hands their thing to whom, so that in the end every stall has exactly what it should? Reason it out together, one pass at a time.

When the last swap comes untangled and each stall holds its own again, a cheer runs the length of the Market Row. Everything is mended. Yet one question still hangs in the air, unanswered: where did all this muddle begin?

Pip the New Mage

Behind a quiet stall at the far end, you find the answer curled up small and trying very hard to be invisible: a young apprentice mage, no older than you, with a pointed hat sitting crooked over a worried face. Their name is Pip, and today is their very first day of magic.

Pip, you learn, had only wanted to help. They had tried a small Change spell to tidy a stall, and the spell had slipped and spun out across the whole market, swapping everything as it went. Frightened of the muddle they had made, and far too shy to own up, Pip had crept away to hide.

There is no scolding here, and there never was anything to fear. Everyone fumbles a spell now and then, and a first day is exactly when it is most likely to happen.



What do you say to Pip? How can you show them that all is well, that no one is cross, and that nobody mended this market alone, you mended it together?

When you tell Pip, gently and truly, that everything is alright, they uncurl and peep out with the smallest of smiles. Then, steadier now, Pip lifts one careful Change and sets the very last thing right, and the whole Market Row breaks into applause. Pip straightens up and stands a little taller than before.

You did this together. You were kind, and you were full of ideas, and on the Isles that is the only way anyone ever wins.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which on the Isles means a few small jobs at once: narrator, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses.

Setting up

- You do not need a printed map for this one. Picture the Market Row, or lay out a few household objects to be the stalls and their goods.
- Each player chooses one magic: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice. Two different magics work best, because combining them is half the fun. (Voice is especially handy here, but every magic has a place.)
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). These are spent and refilled during play.
- Build the muddled goods (a loaf, a pair of boots, a kite, some fruit) from household bits and bricks, so the children can move them about. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Instead each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**. When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge in this story can be played with a single ordinary die, and richer dice sets simply make it feel grander.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to try the same idea again, or
- **Combine two magics** once per stop to pass the challenge with no roll at all (Voice and Light, say, or Change and Grow, working as one).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. So nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed. Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. The lesson underneath the whole game is that you get further together.

The surprise

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a surprise and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for surprises; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll	Surprise
1	A Messenger Butterfly flutters past and gives you one free hint.
2	A kind stallholder hands you a snack: take back one energy star.
3	A tidy little gust of wind: the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Mist Cat appears and purrs. All is well; carry on.
5	You spot a helpful label nobody noticed: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A street musician strikes up a tune and everyone hums along for one happy turn.

How it ends

The market is not put right by catching anyone out. The muddle was made by Pip, a kind apprentice mage on their first day, whose Change spell slipped and who was too shy to admit it. The adventure is won when the children reassure Pip, show that mistakes are mended together, and give them the courage to set the last thing right. Let that land gently; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for how to play the ending, and for the solutions to the three stops.

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward good ideas and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Muddled Stalls (Easy)

The challenge. Every object has jumped to the wrong stall. The players need a way to discover where each thing truly belongs.

Intended solutions. Any of the magics can help:

- **Voice** is the natural fit: ask each object where its home is, and it will happily tell you (the boots want the cobbler, the bread wants the baker, and so on).
- **Light** reveals a faint matching mark or colour that pairs each object to its stall.
- **Change** can mend a torn label so a stall can be read again.

Fallback. If a roll misses, the Mist Cat picks up one object in its mouth and carries it pointedly to the right stall, showing the children how, then they spend an energy star or combine two magics to finish the easy ones. Nobody is stuck for long.

Stop 2: The Memory of the Market (Normal)

The challenge. To return the rest, the players must remember the market as it was: which goods belonged at which stall.

Solution. This is a **memory** moment. The four pairings are:

- bread goes to the **baker**
- fruit goes to the **greengrocer**
- shoes go to the **cobbler**
- toys go to the **toymaker**

The Talking Flower hums the stalls in order to help. Let the children recall and place each pairing. Working it out with the flower's help still counts as a full success.

Fallback. If they freeze, have the Talking Flower sing the order slowly, one stall at a time, and let the players place one pairing per line. Getting there with a nudge tops up an energy star.

Stop 3: The Last Swap (Normal)

The challenge. Three stalls are tangled in a loop: the baker holds boots, the cobbler holds a kite, and the toymaker holds bread. The players must work out the passes that put everything right.

Solution. Each stall's own goods are: baker = bread, cobbler = shoes (boots), toymaker = toys (the kite). So it is a three-step ring:

- the **baker** passes the boots to the **cobbler**,
- the **cobbler** passes the kite to the **toymaker**,
- the **toymaker** passes the bread to the **baker**.

Then everyone holds their own. Lay out three objects and three stalls so the children can physically move them; the logic clicks once they see it as a ring.

Fallback. If they are stuck, the Mist Cat nudges the boots toward the cobbler to start the chain ("boots belong with shoes"), and the rest tends to follow. Solving it with one nudge is a full success.

Pip the New Mage (no roll)

This is the resolution, not a puzzle, so there is no band and no roll. Behind a stall the players find **Pip**, a kind apprentice mage on their very first day, whose Change spell slipped and muddled the market, and who hid away out of worry and shyness.

Play it softly. Let the children decide how to reach out: a kind word, a reminder that everyone makes mistakes, an offer to stand beside Pip while they try again. There is no scolding and no trick. When the children reassure Pip, Pip finds the courage to set the last thing right with a careful Change, and the market cheers. End on that warmth. The children have won by being kind and full of ideas, which is the only way anyone wins on the Isles.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.